SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #31 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

"My worth depends on my success."

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Where it often comes from

Praise for good grades, wins, promotions, and paychecks teaches that we are loved for what we achieve. In competitive cultures, success becomes the scorecard of worth, and failure feels like personal defect. Even in church, the successful may be applauded most.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast." Jesus asks, "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made." "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Our worth was established before we achieved anything. Work is good, and diligence matters, but they are expressions of life, not its foundation.

> *"For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast"* (Ephesians 2:8–9).

Also see

> "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" (Mark 8:36).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast and immovable. Always excel in the work of the Lord, because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain" (1 Corinthians 15:58).

Common self-statements

- I am what I achieve.
- If I stop succeeding, I am nothing.
- My value goes up and down with results.
- I have to keep proving myself.
- Failure means I am a failure.
- I have to win to matter.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either a success or a failure.
- Labeling: Calling myself a failure after a setback.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling worthless after a loss and concluding that I am.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must always succeed.

Challenging questions

- When did I first learn that success earns love?
- Who loves me whether I succeed or not?

- What would I be if I lost my title, income, or achievements?
- What does Scripture say about the basis of my worth?
- What do I do when I fail?
- What is one thing I can enjoy this week without measuring it?

Truth summary

> My worth does not rise and fall with my success. I am loved by God and saved by grace. I can work hard and enjoy the fruit, while resting in a worth that was given and cannot be taken.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride
- Salvation
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My worth depends on my success"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My worth depends on my success." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me success earns worth?
- ☐ Who loves me regardless?
- ☐ What would I be without my achievements?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ What do I do when I fail?
- ☐ What can I enjoy without measuring?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am saved by grace, not works.
- ☐ My worth was given before I achieved.
- ☐ What matters is my soul.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ My labor in the Lord is not in vain.
- ☐ I am loved when I fail.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- ☐ Mark 8:36
  "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?"
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Worth beyond results: Each week, note one thing you did without needing it to prove anything.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am saved by grace, so my worth does not depend on success.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Trace the lesson. Write who taught you that success earns worth.
- [ ] Write who you are without it. List five things true of you apart from achievements.
- [ ] Fail on purpose, small. Try something you might not be good at.
- [ ] Read Ephesians 2:8–9. Say it each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My worth depends on my success": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth beyond results
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My worth depends on my success.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have measured myself by success. Thank You that You saved me by grace. Free me to work with joy and rest in the worth You have given. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.